



ers did. Hooda got Arvind Sharma back while Reddy managed to break two of the five TDP MPs. In both cases, the chief ministers aligned their local interests and that of the UPA at the Centre. For Hooda, it was important to quell the rise of the Bhajan Lal-clan while for Reddy, cracking the TDP ranks delivered dividends in Hyderabad.

The strategy of the Congress was both offensive and defensive in nature. Even as it worked on bagging new MPs, one group was focused on denying the Opposition the resources. Maheshbhai Kanodia, the MP from Patan in Gujarat, was strongly advised by doctors not to travel but his party needed him. Former BJP MP from Mumbai, Kirit Somaiya, who was assigned the task of transporting the MP for the trust vote suddenly found no private aircraft available. Wary of the risks, he eventually moved the MP on a regular Kingfisher flight that reached Delhi just before the trust vote. Somaiya believes even the medical advice was doctored by the Congress.

The prime minister, however, kept out of the vote-catching exercise except for one call to the Akalis for support via a "negotiator". But Sonia

played her part well meeting only those she wanted to and calling those who needed to be spoken to. For instance, she made calls to some single-MP parties and to upset Congressmen like R.L. Jalappa, who assured her of his vote. Ajit Singh, who the Congress had tried to soften by naming the Amausi airport after his father Charan Singh, and JD(s) supremo Gowda waited in vain for an invitation to 10 Janpath. Obviously for Sonia, Gowda was a one-horse party as of the three JD(s) MPs, Veerendra Patil was committed to the Left point of view and Shivanna was in the bag. The saga is not without its share of delicious irony. While Amar emerged as the face of "horse-trading", it was the Congress that inflicted the maximum damage. Amar Singh caught in the worry of keeping his flock together eventually delivered just one BJP MP while seven were snared by Congress operators.

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**BACKROOM TRINITY:**  
(From L to R) Deshmukh, Hooda and Reddy were instrumental in luring MPs to vote for the UPA

Considering the desperation and the means adopted, much could have gone wrong. Indeed, it did seem so for sometime when BJP MPs walked into the well of the house with a wad of notes, alleging horse-trading by Congress.